

The Most Boring Superpower on Earth

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Right now, somewhere, a census field representative is knocking on a door for the fourth time this month. Nobody answers. She notes the time, marks the form, and walks to the next house.

I want to argue that this is one of the more consequential things happening today, which I realize is a strange claim to make about a woman failing to talk to anybody.

The mail is not addressed to you

Look closely at the envelope a statistical agency sends you and you may find it isn't addressed to anybody in particular. It goes to "the resident of" a street address.

My first reaction was that this is bureaucratic laziness. It isn't. It's a workaround for the fact that people are slippery and buildings aren't. We move, change names, get divorced, move back in with our parents, stop answering the landlord. The apartment stays exactly where it is. So rather than chase a couple hundred million moving targets, the agency plants itself at a fixed point and waits to see who turns out to live there.

Nobody governs a country on *Dona Silva*

A census on its own produces millions of isolated and fairly useless answers. Mrs. Silva has three rooms and a masonry wall. Her neighbor has four rooms and no piped water. Individually this is gossip. No government does anything with it.

It becomes knowledge only after the answers are aggregated, standardized, and weighted. That third word is doing far more work than it looks like it's doing, and I want to come back to it, because it's where this gets interesting.

The two-poverty problem

Ask how many poor people live in the United States and you get two official answers, and nobody is trying to fix this. There are two measures, and they ask slightly different questions.

The Official Poverty Measure compares your pre-tax money income against a fixed threshold, which in 2025 was \$32,970 for a family of four. It's a blunt instrument, deliberately so: because it has barely changed, you can lay 1965 next to 2025 and the comparison means something.

The Supplemental Poverty Measure counts SNAP benefits, subtracts taxes and medical and work expenses, and adjusts for the inconvenient fact that rent in San Francisco is not rent in rural Mississippi. It's a closer description of how much money a household actually has on a Tuesday.

So there are two poverty rates for one country in one year, describing the same people.

What matters is what each one lets you see. Because the SPM counts benefits, you can watch Social Security lift 28.8 million people over the line in a single year. The OPM can't show you that, not because it's broken but because it was never built to look there. Whether you find that number persuasive is a political argument. Whether you can see it at all is a measurement decision, and the measurement decision came first.

The 61.3% problem (the scary part)

In the 2026 Current Population Survey, the weighted response rate dropped to 61.3%, down from 62.0%.

That's seven tenths of a percentage point, which sounds like the sort of thing only a statistician could be upset about.

The trouble is that the people who don't answer aren't a random slice of the country. If households working two jobs are harder to catch at home, the resulting picture tilts toward everyone who had a free Tuesday afternoon. Nothing in the data announces this. It just comes out slightly richer than the country it describes.

So agencies apply survey weights. If they know a group is underrepresented, they count each response from that group as more than one.

I found this alarming when I first understood it, and I've mostly stopped finding it alarming, though not entirely. Weighting is a judgment call, made by people who had to assume something about the households they couldn't reach. The number that reaches a policymaker's desk looks like a hard fact. It's a fact with a stack of defensible assumptions underneath it.

Which is a knowledge question wearing a lab coat: how would you ever know whether the correction is a correction or a distortion? You can't check it against the true answer, because the true answer is the thing you were trying to find. What you get instead is the assumptions, written down somewhere a critic can reach them. That's thinner than certainty, and it's most of what any method ever gives you.

And then somebody builds a clinic

In Brazil, 70.9% of people in the South have earnings from work. In the North it's 60.6%. That ten-point gap is the kind of number that moves development money from one region to another. Average monthly earnings reached R\$3,367 in 2025, up 5.4% on the year, which is roughly how a government finds out whether five years of its own policy did anything.

Somewhere downstream of all this, a municipality decides where to put a clinic. That decision is only as good as the count, and the count is only as good as the number of people who bothered to open the envelope.

Which brings us back to the porch

The woman with the clipboard knocks again.

Being counted is the only situation I can think of where "you are a data point" isn't an insult. A neighborhood nobody records is a neighborhood the budget can't see, and the people writing that budget usually aren't being callous about it. They're working from a list.

Which is why she'll come back a fifth time. It's a dull thing to be asked to do, and it carries more leverage than most of what you'll be asked to do this year.